CHAPTER 1 RESEARCH COMPENDIUM

Voices from the Digital Commons: Understanding the New Media of Student Life and Learning

Comprehensive Documentation of Findings, Statistics, and Prose for Chapter 1

Generated: January 2025 **Archive Period**: 2005-2025 **Total Corpus**: 629,430 posts across 12 subreddits

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Part I: Study Foundations

1.1 Opening Frame

1.1.1 March 2020

Since the shift to emergency remote learning in March 2020, digital platforms like Reddit have gained significant traction in the social and academic lives of today's college students. These networks emerged as more than discussion forums or chat rooms; they became dialogic lifelines for students grappling with a global health crisis during what Steve Brier and Michael Fabricant have called "austerity blues" (2016).

1.1.2 The 290% Activity Spike

Key Statistic: In March 2020, activity across CUNY's Reddit communities surged by **290 percent**.

The surge in activity revealed patterns of peer-to-peer support that operate outside institutional channels, with students turning to one another for help with food insecurity, housing crises, financial aid confusion, and mental health struggles. Reddit provided infrastructure for horizontal knowledge sharing, where students helped each other navigate bureaucratic systems, pool educational resources, and coordinate mutual aid at a time when classrooms and administrative offices were otherwise shuttered.

1.1.3 From 929 to 91,505 Posts

Temporal Comparison:

- **Pre-pandemic (2011 to March 2020)**: 929 posts in r/CUNY
- **Post-pandemic (March 2020 to December 2024)**: 91,505 posts

This return in-person did not slow so much as consolidate student engagement with Reddit, as evidenced by the ten-year growth rate of the r/CUNY subreddit community:

- **2019-2021**: Membership grew from 1.3k to just under 5k
- **By 2024**: Exceeded 10k members, continuing to climb well after the phased reopening period had concluded

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1.2 Research Questions

1.2.1 Primary Questions

1. In the afterlife of the COVID-19 pandemic, why have students continued to turn to Reddit to meet their educational needs?
2. What kinds of information and support did they look for in these social networks that their college did not provide?
3. How do we reconcile the need for financial aid disbursement megathreads with the official communication channels and administrative responsibilities of the university?

1.2.2 Secondary/Guiding Questions

4. In our complicated and precarious digital era, how and why do established university practices miss the mark with today's student communities?
5. How can investigating the digital culture and communication practices of our students on these platforms expose shortcomings at CUNY and in higher education more broadly?
6. What happens when students take matters into their own hands, and how does their bottom-up response shed light on both the state of public higher education and the networked publics it invokes among student communities?

1.2.3 Methodological Questions

7. How do Reddit's platform affordances (persistence, searchability, replicability, scalability) enable crisis-responsive discourse communities?

8. What distinguishes vernacular literacies enacted on Reddit from institutionally-mediated communication?
9. How can computational analysis of discourse patterns complement ethnographic methods?

1.3 Study Scope

1.3.1 Population: Reddit-Participating CUNY Students

This dissertation examines **273,702 posts** across **8 CUNY subreddit communities** from 2011-2025, revealing how Reddit-participating students transform generic platform features into survival infrastructure.

Critical Boundary: Analysis focuses exclusively on students who participate in Reddit communities—the subset of which represents digitally-engaged students comfortable with pseudonymous platform discourse, not CUNY's entire student body.

1.3.2 Archive: 273,702 Posts (2011-2025)

The 8 subreddit communities examined:

- r/CUNY
- r/Baruch
- r/HunterCollege
- r/QueensCollege
- r/CCNY
- r/BrooklynCollege
- r/JohnJay
- r/CUNYuncensored

1.3.3 Limitations and Boundaries

Students who relied on in-person peer networks, family support systems, or other digital platforms remain outside this study's scope. Reddit data is treated as a window into specific peer support practices rather than representative of all CUNY student experiences.

Students use Reddit for questions that require archived answers—from registration procedures to course recommendations to financial-aid deadlines—forming a shifting boundary and hyperlocal context that calls for attending to a specific set of peer-support practices while necessarily leaving others outside the frame.

1.3.4 What This Study Is Not

This dissertation pursues inquiry to highlight contradictions between official university services and the everyday needs of college students who turn to Reddit for support they do not receive from their CUNY college. It does not:

- Claim to represent all CUNY students
- Propose technological solutions to structural problems
- Advocate for institutional adoption of Reddit
- Generalize beyond the Reddit-participating population

1.4 Theoretical Foundations

1.4.1 Vernacular Literacies (Barton & Hamilton)

Students enact literate repertoires that are vernacular in the sense developed by Barton and Hamilton (1998): situated, self-sponsored, and grounded in the lived conditions of participants rather than in the expectations of institutional authority. Within these subreddits, writing becomes a means of coordination and survival. Students compose posts and comment threads that record bureaucratic know-how, translate administrative language into accessible terms, and narrate everyday struggles in ways that foster recognition among peers. These are literacies of maintenance and repair, through which students render visible the social labor of staying enrolled, finding aid, and navigating systems not built with them in mind.

1.4.2 Networked Publics (boyd)

Through its technical design, the platform activates boyd's (2011) four affordances of networked publics:

- **Persistence**: Content remains available across years
- **Searchability**: Students can locate older crisis posts
- **Replicability**: Tactical knowledge moves across campuses
- **Scalability**: Peer support reaches beyond what individual advisors could provide during office hours

These affordances prove particularly consequential for understanding crisis response when a Hunter College student posts about housing insecurity at 2am—that post persists indefinitely, becoming searchable by future students facing similar crises while the knowledge replicates across CUNY campuses and support scales beyond what individual advisors could provide during office hours.

1.4.3 Contextual Integrity (Nissenbaum)

Reddit's pseudonymity enables what Proferes (2017) calls "context collapse management": the strategic separation of multiple social contexts that would normally be collapsed together in institutionally-mediated spaces. Users identified by chosen handles rather than legal names can make vulnerable disclosures that institutional surveillance would inhibit.

Critical scholarship on contextual integrity (Nissenbaum 2004, 2010) and context collapse (boyd 2014) complicates this apparent protection, reminding us that privacy depends on appropriate information flows between contexts that can be violated even when formal anonymity exists. The permanence of Reddit archives, the platform's corporate interest in user data, and the visibility of participation patterns all challenge the assumption that pseudonymity creates genuine context separation.

Yet despite these limitations, Reddit's pseudonymous architecture still shapes what discourse becomes possible. Struggles that remain hidden in campus interactions can surface in Reddit threads precisely because the formal separation of contexts, however fragile, enables students to take risks they wouldn't take under institutional observation.

1.4.4 Austerity Blues (Brier & Fabricant)

CUNY's recent history exemplifies intersecting pressures rather than deviating from them. The system's 2023 budget reductions—over $150 million in city funding cuts that eliminated hundreds of positions—extend what scholars have described as a "slow-burn, decades-long state of crisis" (Brier and Fabricant 213).

Key Statistics:

- State appropriations per full-time enrollee dropped from $9,513.86 in 2007 to $5,309.87 in 2008, and further to $2,683.07 in 2017—a **72-percent decline**
- CUNY's operating budget declined **19 percent** between 2008 and 2020 while enrollment increased **11 percent**

This local austerity mirrors national patterns in large urban public universities, from California to Illinois to Texas, where rising enrollments of working-class and immigrant students have been met with stagnant state funding and escalating costs.

1.4.5 Local Publics Framework (Long)

The project employs Elenore Long's framework for studying local publics by engaging:

- The specific contexts or locations that shape discursive sites
- The tenor, genre, or register of the discourse
- The literacies employed to engage publicly
- The iterative process of rhetorical invention that members use to determine what to say, do, and write (2008)

This framework offers a critical lexicon for exploring how these communities carve out "scraps of discursive space" distinct from the university and the dominant public it represents (Wells, 326).

1.4.6 Organized Abandonment (Gilmore)

Reddit preserves evidence of what doesn't work: crashed CUNYfirst servers, unreachable advisors, contradictory financial aid communications, and broken elevators trapping students. Unlike institutional assessments reporting successes or exit surveys reaching only completers, Reddit captures frustration, failure, and abandonment from those institutions lose. This documentation of organized abandonment (Gilmore 2007) emerges precisely because Reddit operates outside institutional control.

Part II: Dataset Architecture

2.1 CUNY Subreddit Corpus

2.1.1 r/CUNY Statistics

Metric	Value
Total Posts	112,248

Submissions	31,887
Comments	80,361
Users	6,947 total
Processed	6,772 (97.4%)
Pending	17
Failed	158
Database Size	92M

2.1.2 r/Baruch Statistics

Metric	**Value**
Total Posts	138,101
Submissions	44,742
Comments	93,359
Users	7,179 total
Processed	6,842 (95.3%)
Pending	0
Failed	337
Database Size	141M

2.1.3 r/HunterCollege Statistics

Metric	Value
Total Posts	31,806
Submissions	10,035
Comments	21,771
Users	3,074 total
Processed	3,029 (98.5%)
Pending	0
Failed	45
Database Size	16M

2.1.4 r/QueensCollege Statistics

Metric	Value
Total Posts	34,518
Submissions	11,801
Comments	22,717
Users	2,758 total
Processed	2,684 (97.3%)
Pending	0
Failed	74
Database Size	20M

2.1.5 r/CCNY Statistics

Metric	Value
Total Posts	12,022
Submissions	3,916
Comments	8,106
Users	1,484 total
Processed	1,453 (97.9%)
Pending	0
Failed	31
Database Size	6.2M

2.1.6 r/BrooklynCollege Statistics

Metric	Value
Total Posts	1,603
Submissions	781
Comments	822
Users	447 total
Processed	435 (97.3%)
Pending	0

Failed	12
Database Size	1.1M

2.1.7 r/JohnJay Statistics

Metric	**Value**
Total Posts	237
Submissions	65
Comments	172
Users	99 total
Processed	94 (94.9%)
Pending	0
Failed	5
Database Size	184K

2.1.8 r/CUNYuncensored Statistics

Metric	**Value**
Total Posts	148
Submissions	59
Comments	89
Users	79 total

Processed	74 (93.6%)
Pending	0
Failed	5
Database Size	264K
Note	Created March 11, 2020

2.2 Comparative University Corpus

2.2.1 r/NYU Statistics

Metric	**Value**
Total Posts	174,396
Submissions	29,637
Comments	144,759
Users	19,391 total
Processed	18,691 (96.3%)
Failed	700
Database Size	78M

2.2.2 r/columbia Statistics

Metric	Value
Total Posts	97,797
Submissions	10,921
Comments	86,876
Users	9,769 total
Processed	9,165 (93.8%)
Pending	3
Failed	601
Database Size	51M

2.2.3 r/Fordham Statistics

Metric	Value
Total Posts	24,805
Submissions	3,346
Comments	21,459
Users	3,440 total
Processed	3,333 (96.8%)
Failed	107
Database Size	12M

2.2.4 r/STJOHNS Statistics

Metric	Value
Total Posts	1,749
Submissions	440
Comments	1,309
Users	610 total
Processed	592 (97.0%)
Failed	18
Database Size	1.0M

2.3 User Processing Metrics

2.3.1 Aggregate Totals

Category	CUNY (8 subs)	Comparative (4 subs)	Combined
Total Users	22,067	33,210	55,277
Processed	21,383	31,781	53,164
Processing Rate	96.9%	95.7%	96.1%
Pending	17	3	20
Failed	667	1,426	2,093

2.3.2 Processing Rates by Subreddit

Subreddit	Processing Rate
HunterCollege	98.5%
CCNY	97.9%
CUNY	97.4%
BrooklynCollege	97.3%
QueensCollege	97.3%
STJOHNS	97.0%
Fordham	96.8%
NYU	96.3%
Baruch	95.3%
JohnJay	94.9%
CUNYuncensored	93.6%
columbia	93.8%

2.4 Data Quality Validation

2.4.1 Orphan Recovery Methodology

The user-centric scraping methodology inverts conventional approaches by sampling users and reconstructing complete participation histories, bypassing Reddit's 1000-item API limitation while capturing marginalized voices that conventional methods miss.

Processing Phases:

1. **Phase 1**: Initial user discovery from subreddit
2. **Phase 1.2**: User network expansion
3. **Phase 2**: Process all discovered users
4. **Phase 2.5**: Process remaining pending users
5. **Phase 2.6**: Comprehensive orphan recovery (automatic)
6. **Phase 3**: Export data and generate reports

2.4.2 Completion Rates Target

Target: 98%+ completion across all databases

Data validation revealed that conventional methods systematically exclude the most vulnerable participants—one-time crisis posters who seek help then vanish. Recovery operations preserve these voices as an act of methodological justice.

2.4.3 Evidence ID Preservation Protocol

All evidence preserved with citation-ready IDs:

- **Submissions**: submission_[id] (e.g., submission_1ic1a4p)
- **Comments**: comment_[id] (e.g., comment_mz3uy41)

Database schema requires:

- Submission IDs with t3_ prefix
- Comment IDs with t1_ prefix
- Proper parent_id linkage for thread reconstruction

Part III: Long-Term Growth Patterns

3.1 Subreddit Emergence Timeline

3.1.1 Earliest Activity by Campus

Subreddit	Earliest Activity	First Submission ID
r/Baruch	July 3, 2005	t3g302
r/CUNY	July 20, 2005	ikx941
r/QueensCollege	August 6, 2011	t3_jay1x
r/BrooklynCollege	August 7, 2011	jb8rr
r/HunterCollege	August 28, 2011	t3_jwph3
r/CCNY	October 17, 2011	t3_leto7
r/JohnJay	January 7, 2015	t3_1qkaq0
r/CUNYuncensored	March 11, 2020	t3_1583885269

3.1.2 August 2011 Wave

Most campus subreddits activated in **August 2011**, suggesting coordinated or viral spread:

- Initial posts typically appeared just before fall semester start
- Registration complaint posts clustered in October-November (registration period)
- Pattern suggests organic student-driven discovery

3.1.3 r/CUNYuncensored: Pandemic Emergence

Created **March 11, 2020**—the same week WHO declared COVID-19 a global pandemic. Represents splinter community formation during institutional crisis.

3.2 Pre-Pandemic Growth (2011-2019)

3.2.1 Pre-2020 Baseline Activity

Total Pre-2020 Posts: 17,999 (across all CUNY subreddits)

Subreddit	Pre-2020 Users	Pre-2020 Posts
Baruch	997	11,061
QueensCollege	522	4,185
HunterCollege	288	1,102
CUNY	206	1,052
CCNY	109	371
BrooklynCollege	71	194
JohnJay	14	17

3.2.2 Early Thematic Patterns (2011-2013)

Most Dominant Early Theme: Students seeking social connections in commuter-heavy environments

Evidence Examples:

- Hunter College: t3_jwph3 (Aug 28, 2011) - "Welcome to r/HunterCollege!" - First post establishing community
- Queens College: t3_k6n3g (Sep 6, 2011) - "QCeddit Meetup?" - Organizing Reddit meetups with "password is bacon"
- Hunter College: t3_k3ily (Sep 3, 2011) - "Does anyone want to have a meet-up?"
- Baruch: t3_kep7y (Sep 13, 2011) - "Should we Redditors create a Baruch Reddit Club?"

3.3 Pandemic Transition (March 2020)

3.3.1 Activity Spike Quantification

290% activity increase in March 2020

Metric	Pre-March 2020	Post-March 2020	Change
r/CUNY posts	929	91,505	+9,750%
Active users	~1,300	~10,000+	+669%

3.3.2 Topic Shifts

New discourse patterns emerged post-March 2020:

- Remote learning logistics
- Financial aid disbursement confusion
- Housing displacement
- Mental health crisis support
- Food insecurity resource sharing

3.3.3 New User Influx Characteristics

Post-pandemic users demonstrated:

- Higher post frequency per user
- More crisis-oriented content
- Increased late-night activity
- Greater engagement with mutual aid threads

3.4 Post-Pandemic Persistence (2021-2025)

3.4.1 Membership Growth Trajectory

Period	r/CUNY Membership
2019	~1,300
2021	~5,000
2024	10,000+

Growth continued well after phased reopening concluded, suggesting Reddit became permanent infrastructure rather than emergency response.

3.4.2 Sustained Engagement

Despite return to in-person (Fall 2021, ~45% of courses hybrid/in-person):

- Engagement consolidated rather than declined
- Membership growth accelerated
- New crisis patterns (January 2025 federal aid suspension) triggered similar response patterns

3.4.3 Why Students Keep Coming Back

Reddit provides:

- Archived institutional knowledge
- Peer validation for struggles
- Anonymous crisis disclosure space
- Faster response than institutional channels
- Cross-campus tactical knowledge sharing

Part IV: Crisis Intensification Analysis

4.1 Methodology

4.1.1 Pre-2020 vs Post-2020 Cutoff

Time cutoff: January 1, 2020 00:00:00 UTC (Unix timestamp: 1577836800)

4.1.2 Keyword Search Protocols

- Case-insensitive substring matching in comments and submissions
- Databases analyzed: All 8 CUNY subreddits
- Evidence IDs preserved for academic citation

4.1.3 Intensification Ratio Calculations

Intensification Ratio = Post-2020 Count / Pre-2020 Count

4.2 Food Insecurity (12.9x Intensification)

4.2.1 Pre-2020: 7 Mentions

Only 7 mentions of food insecurity-related terms across all CUNY subreddits before January 2020.

4.2.2 Post-2020: 90 Mentions

90 mentions post-pandemic—a **12.9x increase**

4.2.3 Campus-Specific Patterns

Campus	Pre-2020	Post-2020	Ratio
Baruch	~1	~30	**30x**
Hunter	0	20	**∞**
CUNY (main)	-	-	-
CCNY	-	-	-
QueensCollege	-	-	-

Hunter College went from 0 mentions to 20, indicating emergence of new crisis discourse.

4.2.4 Key Evidence Posts

CUNY (Post-2020):

[comment_mz3uy41] Score: 88 "Your school should have an emergency fund, look for it first. They may also have a food pantry and c..."

Baruch (Post-2020):

[comment_m8mrtfv] Score: 7 "USG every now and agian does a coat/clothes drive. Near BOSS in NVC is a food pantry, here is more d..."

HunterCollege (Post-2020):

[comment_mpyg9aa] Score: 15 "Make sure to attend events that give free food, and take advantage of food pantry..."

[comment_lgdg1or] Score: 8 "There's a food pantry that's open at Hunter. You could grab some food from there to alleviate some o..."

CUNYuncensored (Post-2020):

[submission_fio9cw] Score: 7 "Food Pantry hours highlighted..."

4.3 Financial Aid (23.7x Intensification)

4.3.1 Overall Statistics

Metric	Pre-2020	Post-2020	Ratio
Total Mentions	992	23,498	**23.7x**

4.3.2 FAFSA Mentions

30.3x increase in FAFSA-related discussions

4.3.3 TAP Mentions

27.4x increase in New York State TAP aid discussions

4.3.4 Excelsior Mentions

23.1x increase in Excelsior "free tuition" program discussions, suggesting problems with program implementation

4.3.5 r/CUNY as Clearinghouse

Main r/CUNY subreddit shows **65.7x intensification**, becoming central clearinghouse for aid anxiety across all campuses.

4.3.6 Key Evidence Posts

[comment_lbv7vid] (r/CUNY) "I applied to John Jay late and it took like 30 hours for it to be on cuny first"

[comment_mod89uz] (r/CUNY) "I emailed the financial aid and bursar office of my college but haven't gotten a response"

[comment_lmgmoro] (r/CUNY) "Keep it together, don't drop out and see it through"

4.4 Housing Crisis (29.4x Intensification)

4.4.1 Pre-2020: 11 Mentions

Minimal housing crisis discourse before pandemic.

4.4.2 Post-2020: 323 Mentions

29.4x intensification—second highest among all crisis categories.

4.4.3 Urgency Markers

Urgency Indicators	Pre-2020	Post-2020
"eviction" mentions	0	19
"housing insecurity"	0	emerged
Urgent help requests	0	multiple

New discourse terms emerged post-2020 that had no pre-pandemic presence.

4.4.4 Hunter (38x) and Manhattan Pressures

Hunter College shows **38x increase**, reflecting Manhattan housing pressures and limited campus housing options.

4.5 Mental Health (16.9x Intensification)

4.5.1 Overall Statistics

Metric	Pre-2020	Post-2020	Ratio
Total Mentions	170	2,879	**16.9x**

4.5.2 Late-Night Posts

Mental health late-night posts (midnight-6am): **17.9x increase**

4.5.3 Engagement Scores

Period	Average Score
Pre-2020	5.8
Post-2020	7.3

Higher engagement post-pandemic suggests community rallied around mental health support.

4.5.4 r/CUNY as Mental Health Support Hub

Main r/CUNY subreddit shows **64.8x increase** in mental health discussions, becoming primary mental health peer support venue.

4.5.5 Key Late-Night Evidence Posts

CUNY (Late Night Posts):

[comment_k91iid7] 2023-11-13 02:49 "Guys I need some advice. I'm starting in the spring semester in ccny. But I'm stressing out so bad..."

[comment_kfybo12] 2024-01-02 03:17 "It's giving me so much anxiety because I really want to be in the class! 'Get this schedule' is gra..."

Baruch (Late Night Posts):

[comment_hd6xlvm] 2021-09-17 06:50 "Honestly because of the anxiety and stressed it caused me. I had a high GPA, so it wasn't like I was..."

[comment_i9wkl9n] 2022-05-25 02:06 "I'm actually having anxiety about graduating… I feel like everyone else is just excited..."

HunterCollege (Late Night Posts):

[comment_goobw0g] 2021-02-25 00:36 "They're not exaggerating. It's just the way the bio department is set up. There's so much competitio..."

4.6 CUNYfirst Systems (13.9x Intensification)

4.6.1 Overall Statistics

Metric	Pre-2020	Post-2020	Ratio
Total Mentions	457	6,350	**13.9x**

4.6.2 Help-Seeking Percentage

Period	Help-Seeking %
Pre-2020	16.2%
Post-2020	21.6%

Proportion of posts seeking help increased, suggesting greater desperation.

4.6.3 Negative Sentiment Stability

Negative sentiment remained stable (~3.5%), suggesting persistent systemic issues rather than temporary frustrations.

4.6.4 CCNY Intensification

CCNY shows **46x intensification**, indicating campus-specific registration crises.

4.6.5 Historical Context

Early CUNYfirst critique from 2013:

[t3_1fodsk] (r/CUNY, Jun 4, 2013) "Who here despises the current CunyFirst?" Described as "piece of unintuitive garbage that looks like it was made in the 90's" costing $600 million

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Part V: User Growth vs Crisis Validation

5.1 Validation Methodology

5.1.1 Research Question

Does the 290% activity spike represent **real crisis intensification** or merely **platform adoption** (more people discovering Reddit)?

5.1.2 Key Metrics

- **User Growth Ratio**: How many more unique users participated post-2020 vs pre-2020
- **Content Growth Ratio**: How much more content was created post-2020 vs pre-2020
- **Posts Per User Ratio**: How much individual posting behavior changed

5.1.3 Interpretation Framework

Pattern	Interpretation
User growth ≈ Content growth	Platform adoption shift (more people discussing same issues)
Content growth >> User growth	**Real crisis intensification** (same people experiencing more/worse crises)
Posts/user increased significantly	Individual crisis intensity increased

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5.2 By-Subreddit Validation

Subreddit	Pre-2020 Users	Post-2020 Users	User Growth	Pre-2020 Posts	Post-2020 Posts	Content Growth	Posts/User Change
Baruch	997	7,866	7.9x	11,061	109,976	9.9x	1.3x
BrooklynCollege	71	358	5.0x	194	1,084	5.6x	1.1x
CCNY	109	1,367	12.5x	371	10,015	**27.0x**	**2.2x**
CUNY	206	8,966	**43.5x**	1,052	93,107	**88.5x**	**2.0x**
HunterCollege	288	2,995	10.4x	1,102	26,553	**24.1x**	**2.3x**
JohnJay	14	74	5.3x	17	186	10.9x	2.1x

QueensCollege	522	2,644	5.1x	4,185	24,442	5.8x	1.2x

5.3 Aggregate Finding

5.3.1 Aggregate Averages

Metric	Value
Average User Growth	12.8x
Average Content Growth	24.6x
Average Posts/User Change	1.7x

5.3.2 Validation Result

VALIDATION RESULT: Evidence supports REAL CRISIS INTENSIFICATION

The disproportionate content growth (24.6x) compared to user growth (12.8x) indicates that existing community members were experiencing and discussing crises at significantly higher rates post-2020, rather than simply more users joining the platform.

The 1.7x increase in posts per user further confirms that individual students were posting nearly twice as much as before—a behavioral change consistent with increased need rather than mere platform discovery.

Part VI: Temporal Patterns

6.1 Pre-Pandemic Baseline (2018-2019)

6.1.1 Overall Activity Distribution

Metric	Value
Total posts analyzed (2018-2019)	17,999
Late-night posts (00:00-05:59)	1,982 (11.0%)
Daytime posts (06:00-23:59)	16,017 (89.0%)

6.1.2 Late-Night Engagement Baseline

Time Period	Average Score
Late-night (midnight-6am)	2.82
Daytime (6am-midnight)	2.90
Differential	-0.08 (-2.8%)

6.1.3 Hourly Distribution Table (2018-2019)

Hour	Time Range	Post Count	Avg Score
00	00:00-00:59	807	2.75
01	01:00-01:59	535	2.88
02	02:00-02:59	272	2.80
03	03:00-03:59	164	3.13
04	04:00-04:59	124	2.93
05	05:00-05:59	80	2.30

12	12:00-12:59	967	2.97
13	13:00-13:59	1,104	2.97
16	16:00-16:59	1,117	2.96
21	21:00-21:59	1,204	3.14

6.1.4 Interpretation

Late-night activity (midnight-6am) comprised 11.0% of total posting during 2018-2019. While some late-night activity existed before the pandemic, it was relatively limited. This baseline allows measurement of the expansion of 24/7 peer support during and after the pandemic period.

6.2 Crisis Temporality

6.2.1 Post-Pandemic Late-Night Activity

Late-night mental health posts: 17.9x increase post-pandemic

6.2.2 2-3am Activity Patterns

Post-pandemic, the 2-3am window shows:

- Higher engagement scores (4.35 avg vs 2.87 evening)
- More crisis-oriented content
- Greater peer response rates

6.2.3 When Institutions Sleep

Students create 24/7 support networks precisely when institutional offices are closed. The platform creates what Zhu et al. (2023) document as crisis-responsive discourse communities that emerge when institutional channels prove inadequate.

6.3 Peak Activity Windows

6.3.1 Registration Periods

Registration complaint posts cluster in October-November across all CUNY subreddits, consistent with fall registration anxiety.

6.3.2 Financial Aid Deadlines

Activity spikes correlate with:

- FAFSA deadlines
- TAP certification periods
- Excelsior eligibility windows
- Bursar hold deadlines

6.3.3 Finals Week Clustering

Food insecurity posts cluster around finals weeks, when students face compounded time and resource pressures.

Part VII: Linguistic & Discourse Analysis

7.1 Differential N-gram Patterns

7.1.1 CUNY-Unique Trigrams (Top 20)

Rank	Trigram	Interpretation
1	"what do you"	Interrogative help-seeking
2	"constant issues with"	System failure discourse
3	"if you get"	Conditional knowledge sharing
4	"you go to"	Campus navigation
5	"ll be able"	Future possibility framing
6	"ll be fine"	Reassurance language
7	"the spring semester"	Temporal planning
8	"much better experiences"	Comparative evaluation
9	"ll need to"	Requirement articulation
10	"your financial aid"	Economic precarity marker

7.1.2 Comparative-Unique Trigrams (Elite Universities)

Rank	Trigram	Interpretation
1	"that s not"	Corrective discourse
2	"you ll get"	Certainty language
3	"and i got"	Success narratives
4	"re going to"	Future confidence

5	"post has been"	Moderation language
6	"the fact that"	Analytical framing
7	"in terms of"	Academic discourse
8	"direct all questions"	Institutional authority
9	"there is no"	Definitive statements
10	"go to a"	Generic navigation

7.1.3 Interrogative Help-Seeking Patterns

CUNY discourse shows significantly higher use of question-based peer support:

- "anyone else" patterns appear **3x more frequently**
- "does anyone know" structures dominate information seeking
- "can someone help" reflects institutional support gaps

7.2 Financial Precarity Language

7.2.1 "financial aid office" Frequency

7.94x more frequently in CUNY discourse vs comparative universities

7.2.2 "bursar hold" Mentions

University	Mentions
CUNY	189
NYU	3

Columbia	0

Bursar hold language appears almost exclusively in CUNY discourse.

7.2.3 Conditional Future Framing

Financial aid discussions appear in **5.47% of CUNY comments** vs **4.08%** in comparative universities—a significant marker of economic vulnerability.

Students speak in contingencies because their futures are contingent:

- "if you don't" appears with **1.92x frequency**
- "as long as you" shows **1.98x ratio**
- "you will have to" demonstrates **76.13x higher usage**

7.3 System Navigation Vocabulary

7.3.1 CUNYfirst Dialect (+2.18% differential)

The highest differential appears in system-specific discourse:

- CUNY: 2.86% prevalence
- Comparative universities: 0.69%
- **Ratio: 4.14x**

7.3.2 "you will have to" (76.13x CUNY)

This prescriptive guidance language fills institutional voids, with peers providing the procedural knowledge that advisors don't communicate.

7.3.3 "won't be able to" (13.63x CUNY)

Reflects precarity framing where students anticipate system failures and communicate constraints proactively.

7.4 Temporal Stress Markers

7.4.1 Five-gram Analysis

Pattern	CUNY Ratio
"at the end of the semester"	**10.18x**
"won't be able to"	**13.63x**

7.4.2 "due tomorrow" Clustering

Deadline panic language clusters more densely in CUNY discourse, reflecting compressed time horizons of working students.

7.4.3 Registration Anxiety Language

Registration-specific anxiety markers:

- "can't get the classes i need"
- "waitlist position"
- "registration appointment"
- "dropped for non-payment"

7.5 Comparative University Contrasts

7.5.1 CUNY vs NYU Differentials

Pattern	CUNY	NYU	Interpretation
"bursar hold"	189	3	Financial precarity

"financial aid office"	High	Lower	Institutional navigation
"commute"	High	Low	Physical access

7.5.2 CUNY vs Columbia Differentials

Pattern	CUNY:Columbia Ratio
"won't be able to"	1.60x
"have to go in person"	16.37x
System navigation vocabulary	~4x

7.5.3 Centralized vs Distributed Models

CUNY's Distributed Model Creates:

1. **Fragmented Support**: Help-seeking must specify campus context
2. **Transit Discourse**: Inter-campus movement dominates planning
3. **Comparative Evaluation**: Constant campus comparison ("better at Hunter")
4. **System Navigation**: CUNYfirst becomes shared enemy/challenge

Centralized Models (NYU/Columbia) Show:

1. **Unified Identity**: Single subreddit creates cohesive discourse
2. **Institutional Presence**: More official responses and moderation
3. **Resource Assumption**: Less discussion of scarcity
4. **Social Capital**: Networking language more prevalent

7.6 Thematic Category Frequency Table

Category	CUNY Frequency	Comparative Frequency	Ratio	Interpretation
Commuter Survival	2.81x higher	Lower	2.81x	Distributed campus reality
Resource Arbitrage	1.94x higher	Lower	1.94x	Unequal resource distribution
Financial Precarity	6.52x higher	Much lower	**6.52x**	Economic vulnerability
CUNYfirst Dialects	∞ (unique)	Absent	∞	System-specific failures
Crisis Temporality	Present	Present	1.0x	Universal student anxiety

---

Part VIII: Thematic Evidence Categories

8.1 Earliest Common Themes (2011-2013)

8.1.1 Social Connection & Community Building (41 occurrences)

The most dominant early theme across all CUNY subreddits was students seeking social connections in commuter-heavy environments.

Evidence Examples:

[t3_jwph3] r/HunterCollege (Aug 28, 2011) "Welcome to r/HunterCollege!" - First post establishing community

[t3_k6n3g] r/QueensCollege (Sep 6, 2011) "QCeddit Meetup?" - Organizing Reddit meetups with "password is bacon"

[t3_k3ily] r/HunterCollege (Sep 3, 2011) "Does anyone want to have a meet-up?"

[t3_kep7y] r/Baruch (Sep 13, 2011) "Should we Redditors create a Baruch Reddit Club?"

8.1.2 Registration & Scheduling Challenges (25 occurrences)

CUNYFirst system issues and registration difficulties were persistent early complaints.

Evidence Examples:

[t3_1fodsk] r/CUNY (Jun 4, 2013) "Who here despises the current CunyFirst?" - Detailed critique of system costing $600 million

[t3_mgm1u] r/CCNY (Nov 18, 2011) "Registration is one of the worst times during the semester, yes even compared to finals week"

[t3_lgavp] r/HunterCollege (Oct 18, 2011) "So... when is everyone's registration appointment?" - Students comparing registration times

[t3_kckr8] r/QueensCollege (Sep 12, 2011) "Has anyone had their pending financial aid disappeared? all because you wanted to switch classes"

8.1.3 Food Access & Campus Resources

Students consistently discussed where to find affordable food around campus.

Evidence Examples:

[t3_je1m5] r/CCNY (Aug 10, 2011) "Food around CCNY?" - Seeking "cheap, quick, and delicious" options

[t3_k3419] r/Baruch (Sep 3, 2011) "Favorite place to get lunch at Baruch?" - Discussion of Chinese food, halal carts, dollar pizza

[t3_l1gf0] r/HunterCollege (Oct 5, 2011) "Good eats around Hunter?" - Mapping food deserts around campus

[c2bctn3] r/CCNY (Aug 10, 2011) "halal karts trust me cafe food expensive and well they gt 101 violations"

8.1.4 Financial Aid & Tuition Concerns

Financial pressures were evident from the earliest posts.

Evidence Examples:

[t3_joss3] r/CUNY (Aug 20, 2011) "CUNY Senior College Tuition History, 1978-2012" - Historical documentation

[t3_kckr8] r/QueensCollege (Sep 12, 2011) Financial aid disappearing due to schedule changes

8.1.5 Academic Quality & Professor Reviews

Students shared professor recommendations and warnings.

Evidence Examples:

[t3_m0xhj] r/Baruch (Nov 5, 2011) "What are your favorite and least favorite professors at Baruch?"

[t3_m0yrh] r/Baruch (Nov 5, 2011) "Cheating In Baruch On Exams" - Academic integrity concerns

8.1.6 Infrastructure & Physical Campus Issues

Early complaints about campus infrastructure that would persist for years.

Evidence Examples:

[t3_jcid8] r/HunterCollege (Aug 8, 2011) "Smoking Ban on Hunter's Campus" - Policy implementation challenges

[t3_pbho7] r/Baruch (Feb 5, 2012) "Elevator Etiquette- Twenty third Building" - Detailed elevator usage guidelines

[t3_logrd] r/QueensCollege (Oct 25, 2011) "These Site Kiosk computers SUCK"

8.1.7 Parking & Transportation

Consistent early concern across commuter campuses.

Evidence Example:

[t3_loptw] r/QueensCollege (Oct 25, 2011) "Where the fuck do I park?" - Seeking "super secret, super sexy, parking tips"

8.1.8 Textbook Costs & Exchanges

Students organizing to reduce textbook expenses.

Evidence Examples:

[t3_jb5oa] r/CUNY (Aug 6, 2011) "Best websites for cheap text books"

[t3_ozctj] r/Baruch (Jan 27, 2012) "Selling books? Post here" - Creating marketplace

---

8.2 Crisis Testimonies with Evidence IDs

8.2.1 Food Pantry Evidence

[comment_mz3uy41] Score: 88 "Your school should have an emergency fund, look for it first. They may also have a food pantry..."

[comment_mpyg9aa] Score: 15 "Make sure to attend events that give free food, and take advantage of food pantry..."

[comment_lgdg1or] Score: 8 "There's a food pantry that's open at Hunter. You could grab some food from there to alleviate some o..."

[comment_lojoz1b] Score: 4 "Same boat as you, but I've used the food pantry..."

[submission_wrqmpz] Score: 28 "Queens College Student Resources..."

8.2.2 Late-Night Anxiety Evidence

[comment_k91iid7] 2023-11-13 02:49 "Guys I need some advice. I'm starting in the spring semester in ccny. But I'm stressing out so bad..."

[comment_kfybo12] 2024-01-02 03:17 "It's giving me so much anxiety because I really want to be in the class!"

[comment_hd6xlvm] 2021-09-17 06:50 "Honestly because of the anxiety and stressed it caused me. I had a high GPA, so it wasn't like I was..."

[comment_i9wkl9n] 2022-05-25 02:06 "I'm actually having anxiety about graduating… I feel like everyone else is just excited..."

[comment_n3rnesx] 2025-07-18 01:40 "Me personally I was a freshman last year and I tend to have to some bad social anxiety so I didn't r..."

8.2.3 Financial Emergency Evidence

[t3_85q1zu] 2018-03-20 00:31 (r/CUNY) "TAP EMERGENCY - What's up CUNY, I think I'm in a bad situation. So in my CUNYfirst account shows that I owe money. I received TAP for the Spring but I checked today and it shows that I owe x amount..."

[submission_1ic1a4p] Score: 315 January 2025 federal aid suspension triggering widespread concern

8.2.4 Housing Instability Evidence

Housing urgency markers emerged exclusively post-2020, with 19 posts using urgent terms like "eviction" that had zero presence pre-pandemic.

8.3 Tactical Knowledge Examples

8.3.1 System Workarounds

Students document CUNYfirst navigation strategies:

- Clearing browser cache for stuck sessions
- Optimal times to attempt registration
- Workarounds for common error messages

8.3.2 Registration Hacks

- Best appointment time strategies
- Waitlist position monitoring techniques
- Course swap procedures during add/drop

8.3.3 Financial Aid Navigation

- TAP certification procedures
- Excelsior eligibility maintenance
- Bursar hold resolution pathways
- Appeal process documentation

8.3.4 Course Selection Strategies

- Professor recommendation aggregation
- "Easy A" vs learning tradeoffs
- Schedule optimization for commuters
- Cross-campus course taking via ePermit

8.4 High-Engagement Posts

8.4.1 Community Validation Patterns

Reddit's upvoting mechanism provides built-in community validation:

"upvotes become a necessary way for the user to know what is of value, turning conversations into consumable content" (Panek 2022)

When posts explaining ePermit navigation receive substantial upvotes, this signals that the strategy works and matters to the community. When posts about federal aid suspension panic garner hundreds of upvotes, those votes represent students confirming that the problem resonates widely.

8.4.2 Top-Scored Evidence

Evidence ID	Score	Topic
submission_1ic1a4p	315	January 2025 federal aid suspension
comment_mz3uy41	88	Emergency fund and food pantry guidance
submission_wrqmpz	28	Queens College student resources
comment_mpyg9aa	15	Food pantry recommendation
comment_i51rzut	15	Financial independence advice

Part IX: Austerity Context

9.1 Disinvestment Statistics

9.1.1 State Appropriation Decline (72%)

Year	State Appropriation per FTE
2007	$9,513.86
2008	$5,309.87
2017	$2,683.07
Decline	**72%**

This is the largest decline in any postsecondary education sector in New York State.

9.1.2 Budget Cuts ($150M in 2023)

CUNY's 2023 budget reductions—over $150 million in city funding cuts—eliminated hundreds of positions and extended what scholars have described as a "slow-burn, decades-long state of crisis" (Brier and Fabricant 213).

9.1.3 Enrollment vs Budget Mismatch

Metric	2008-2020 Change
Operating budget	-19%
Enrollment	+11%

This mismatch created:

- Overcrowded classes
- Underpaid adjuncts
- Inadequate mental-health services
- Decaying physical infrastructure

9.2 Student Population Vulnerabilities

9.2.1 First-Generation Students

CUNY enrolls primarily first-generation college students with limited family knowledge of higher education navigation.

9.2.2 Immigrant Populations

Significant immigrant population with additional documentation and language barriers.

9.2.3 Working-Class Demographics

About **70 percent of students** hail from families earning less than $30,000 annually (PSC-CUNY).

9.2.4 Food Insecurity Rates

- **National**: ~41% of students experience food insecurity
- **CUNY (Bronx campuses)**: Over 43% food insecurity (Brier and Fabricant 198)
- **Pandemic surveys**: 18% of CUNY students had gone hungry because they lacked resources

9.2.5 Housing Instability Rates

- **National**: ~45% experience some form of housing instability
- **CUNY (Bronx campuses)**: Nearly 50% housing instability
- **Homelessness risk**: Roughly 1 in 10 students

9.3 Institutional Failures

9.3.1 Advisor Understaffing

Faculty losses meant fewer mentors, limited advising availability, and reduced institutional memory, leaving students in a state of need for the very functions they worked to approximate in their peer spaces online.

9.3.2 Mental Health Service Gaps

One longitudinal study recorded moderate-to-severe depression in more than three-quarters of CUNY respondents and comparable rates of anxiety (Raaper and Brown 9).

9.3.3 Technology Access Divides

- More than **30% of Latinx students** had to share computers for coursework
- Over **half of student-parents** reported sharing computers
- Many lacked reliable broadband access

9.3.4 Faculty Precarity (70% contingent)

Nationally, about **70 percent of faculty positions** were off the tenure track as of 2021 (AAUP), with pandemic-era austerity leading to widespread adjunct layoffs and hiring freezes that further strained existing student support systems.

Part X: Written Prose Compilation

10.1 Current Proposal Text

10.1.1 Opening Frame: "Voices from the Digital Commons"

The hidden curriculum is a shape-shifting composite, and it is made up of the insider knowledge college students never knew they needed to know. Many take for granted the paperwork, the bureaucratic hoops and hurdles, the fine print of learning to play the game of higher education, least of all while navigating a persistent state of crisis and constraint. For college students, the harsh and unaffordable conditions of public higher education is starker than many care to admit. It is a tall task indeed for CUNY's working-class students to pursue a degree, and with it the promise of social mobility, in the long-cast shadow of the Great Recession, the COVID-19 pandemic, and the quickening thaw of a long AI winter. Amidst a second Trump presidency and a volatile technological future, what is a population of largely first-generation, immigrant students to do? At a university system like CUNY—hampered by crumbling facilities, fickle software, understaffed support offices, and decades of disinvestment—how do learners carve out space for themselves in the future tense when institutional systems fail to meet them in the present?

10.1.2 Communities in Flux

Since the shift to emergency remote learning in March 2020, digital platforms like Reddit have gained significant traction in the social and academic lives of today's college students. In March 2020, activity across

CUNY's Reddit communities surged by 290 percent, rising from 929 posts in r/CUNY before the pandemic (2011 to March 2020) to 91,505 posts after the onset of remote learning (March 2020 to December 2024). These networks emerged as more than discussion forums or chat rooms; they became dialogic lifelines for students grappling with a global health crisis during what Steve Brier and Michael Fabricant have called "austerity blues" (2016). The surge in activity revealed patterns of peer-to-peer support that operate outside institutional channels, with students turning to one another for help with food insecurity, housing crises, financial aid confusion, and mental health struggles. In this way, Reddit provided infrastructure for horizontal knowledge sharing, where students helped each other navigate bureaucratic systems, pool educational resources, and coordinate mutual aid at a time when classrooms and administrative offices were otherwise shuttered.

10.1.3 Austerity Blues and Urban Commons

As a public-serving institution, CUNY enrolls primarily first-generation and low-income populations in New York City, educating approximately 225,000 degree-seeking and 200,000 non-matriculating individuals. With a dedicated faculty and staff of 45,000 across twenty-five campuses, CUNY is a crucial pathway to economic security for many working-class and immigrant New Yorkers. Notably, about 70 percent of students hail from families earning less than $30,000 annually (PSC-CUNY). Despite its pivotal role in promoting socioeconomic mobility among working-class students, CUNY has faced sustained disinvestment since the 1990s, with state appropriations plummeting particularly after the 2008 Great Recession.

10.1.4 Contextualizing Reddit

Reddit operates as a distributed network of semi-autonomous communities called subreddits, each maintaining distinct norms, moderation practices, and participant bases while sharing platform-wide technical features. Unlike centralized institutional forums such as Blackboard or university portals, Reddit's architecture enables what Fiesler et al. (2018) call "governance development," where community-specific rules emerge from participant needs rather than administrative mandate. For CUNY students, this means r/Baruch, r/HunterCollege, and r/CUNY coexist as separate communities while platform features enable cross-community information flow through user participation across multiple subreddits.

10.1.5 Research Modes and Methods

Methodologically, I combine discourse analysis and ethnographic fieldwork to highlight student voices, while providing a counterbalance to the "big and broad" datasets that dominate social media research (Housley et al. 2014; Roferes et al. 2021). These mixed methods allow me to examine the interplay between vernacular and institutional discourses as they manifest in student contributions to Reddit, and to situate the "untidy communicative practices" that shape public student life over social media (Hauser 2022). This approach

reframes dominant institutional narratives in terms of vernacular voices and the "street-level give-and-take of contrary viewpoints" that drive community dialogue and real-time correspondence between students on these platforms.

10.1.6 Study Scope and Scale

This dissertation examines 273,702 posts across 8 CUNY subreddit communities from 2011-2025, revealing how Reddit-participating students transform generic platform features into survival infrastructure. The January 2025 federal aid suspension (submission_1ic1a4p, 315 upvotes) triggering widespread concern among this digitally-engaged subset suggests these patterns extend beyond the COVID-19 pandemic to reflect ongoing challenges with institutional support systems.

10.2 Key Synthesis Passages

10.2.1 Vernacular Infrastructure Definition

Students here enact literate repertoires that are vernacular in the sense developed by Barton and Hamilton (1998): situated, self-sponsored, and grounded in the lived conditions of participants rather than in the expectations of institutional authority. Within these subreddits, writing becomes a means of coordination and survival. Students compose posts and comment threads that record bureaucratic know-how, translate administrative language into accessible terms, and narrate everyday struggles in ways that foster recognition among peers. These are literacies of maintenance and repair, through which students render visible the social labor of staying enrolled, finding aid, and navigating systems not built with them in mind.

10.2.2 Crisis Response as Adaptive Behavior

CUNY thus serves as a concentrated case of conditions that define contemporary public higher education: chronic disinvestment, infrastructural decay, contingent labor, and a student body forced to navigate overlapping crises of affordability, housing, mental health, and digital access. These institutional realities make visible why CUNY students have turned to Reddit and Discord as infrastructures of survival and support. Their reliance on such peer networks should be understood not as anomaly but as an adaptive response to structural austerity—a condition shared, in varying degrees, by public colleges nationwide.

10.2.3 Peer Support as Institutional Substitute

Reddit's specific platform architecture matters for this analysis: unlike centralized institutional forums where administrators control moderation, visibility algorithms, and data retention, student-moderated subreddits enable peer governance. Students determine community rules, enforce behavioral norms, and curate collective knowledge without institutional oversight. This autonomy creates conditions where students document institutional failures openly, share tactical knowledge about circumventing bureaucratic obstacles, and coordinate mutual aid independently from official university channels.

Appendices

Appendix A: Database Quick Reference

A.1 Schema Overview

Each SQLite database (databases/current/{subreddit}_historical_data.db) contains:

- users: User processing status tracking (pending/completed/failed)
- submissions: Reddit posts (id with t3_ prefix, author, title, selftext, created_utc, score)
- comments: Reddit comments (id with t1_ prefix, submission_id with t3_ prefix, parent_id, body, author)
- user_activity: User metadata and activity summaries

A.2 Table Structures

submissions table:

id (TEXT) - with t3_ prefix

author (TEXT)

title (TEXT)

selftext (TEXT)

created_utc (INTEGER)

score (INTEGER)

comments table:

id (TEXT) - with t1_ prefix

submission_id (TEXT) - with t3_ prefix

parent_id (TEXT)

body (TEXT)

author (TEXT)

created_utc (INTEGER)

score (INTEGER)

A.3 ID Prefix Conventions

- **Submissions**: t3_ prefix (e.g., t3_1ic1a4p)
- **Comments**: t1_ prefix (e.g., t1_mz3uy41)
- **Citation format**: submission_[id] or comment_[id]

Appendix B: Evidence ID Master List

B.1 Key Submission IDs by Theme

Theme	Submission ID	Score	Description
Federal Aid Crisis	submission_1ic1a4p	315	January 2025 aid suspension
Student Resources	submission_wrqmpz	28	Queens College resources
Food Pantry	submission_fio9cw	7	CUNYuncensored pantry hours
TAP Emergency	t3_85q1zu	-	Late-night TAP crisis
CUNYfirst Critique	t3_1fodsk	-	2013 system critique
Community Building	t3_jwph3	-	First Hunter post
Meetup Organization	t3_k6n3g	-	Queens College meetup

B.2 Key Comment IDs by Theme

Theme	Comment ID	Score	Timestamp
Food Pantry	comment_mz3uy41	88	Post-2020
Food Advice	comment_mpyg9aa	15	Post-2020
Food Resources	comment_lgdg1or	8	Post-2020
Late-Night Anxiety	comment_k91iid7	-	2023-11-13 02:49
Registration Anxiety	comment_kfybo12	-	2024-01-02 03:17
Graduation Anxiety	comment_i9wkl9n	-	2022-05-25 02:06

B.3 High-Score Evidence

Posts with scores indicating significant community validation:

- 315: Federal aid suspension concern
- 88: Emergency fund/food pantry guidance
- 28: Student resources compilation
- 15: Multiple food-related posts

Appendix C: SQL Query Reference

C.1 Intensification Query Template

```
-- Crisis Topic Pre/Post 2020 Comparison

SELECT

  CASE WHEN created_utc < 1577836800 THEN 'pre-2020'

      ELSE 'post-2020' END as period,

  COUNT(*) as count

FROM (

  SELECT created_utc FROM submissions

  WHERE LOWER(title) LIKE '%keyword%' OR LOWER(selftext) LIKE '%keyword%'

  UNION ALL

  SELECT created_utc FROM comments

  WHERE LOWER(body) LIKE '%keyword%'

)
```

```
GROUP BY period;
```

C.2 User Growth Query

```
-- User and Content Growth Validation

SELECT

  CASE WHEN created_utc < 1577836800 THEN 'pre-2020'

      ELSE 'post-2020' END as period,

  COUNT(DISTINCT author) as unique_active_users,

  COUNT(*) as total_posts,

  CAST(COUNT(*) AS REAL) / COUNT(DISTINCT author) as posts_per_user

FROM (

  SELECT author, created_utc FROM submissions

  WHERE author != '[deleted]' AND author IS NOT NULL

  UNION ALL

  SELECT author, created_utc FROM comments

  WHERE author != '[deleted]' AND author IS NOT NULL

)

GROUP BY period;
```

C.3 Temporal Distribution Query

```
-- Hourly Distribution Analysis

SELECT

  CAST(strftime('%H', datetime(created_utc, 'unixepoch')) AS INTEGER) as hour,

  COUNT(*) as post_count,

  AVG(score) as avg_score

FROM (

  SELECT created_utc, score FROM submissions

  UNION ALL

  SELECT created_utc, score FROM comments

)

GROUP BY hour

ORDER BY hour;
```

Appendix D: Methodology Notes

D.1 User-Centric Scraping

The methodology inverts conventional approaches by:

1. Sampling users via subreddit posts
2. Extracting complete user histories
3. Recovering "orphaned" comments referencing missing submissions
4. Preserving one-time crisis posters who would be missed by post-centric methods

This approach bypasses Reddit's 1000-item API limitation while capturing marginalized voices.

D.2 Orphan Recovery Protocol

Orphan recovery ensures data completeness by:

1. Tracking referenced submission IDs during comment extraction
2. Identifying submissions referenced but not captured
3. Fetching missing parent submissions via API
4. Final sweep after user processing completes

Target completion rate: 98%+

D.3 Pre/Post-2020 Cutoff Rationale

Cutoff: January 1, 2020 00:00:00 UTC (Unix timestamp: 1577836800)

This date precedes:

- WHO pandemic declaration (March 11, 2020)
- CUNY remote transition (March 2020)
- r/CUNYuncensored creation (March 11, 2020)

The cutoff enables comparison of established patterns against pandemic-era intensification while ensuring pre-pandemic baseline remains uncontaminated by early pandemic activity.

End of Chapter 1 Research Compendium

Document Statistics:

- Total corpus coverage: 629,430 posts
- CUNY subreddits: 8
- Comparative universities: 4
- Time span: 2005-2025

- Evidence IDs preserved: 50+
- Key statistics compiled: 100+